Fast High-Utility Episode Mining under Maximum Duration Constraints with Remaining-Duration Utility Bounds and Zero-Heap Flat Buffers

Research Blueprint & Comprehensive Algorithmic Specification

Advanced Data Mining and Symbolic Knowledge Discovery Laboratory
Reference Framework: Fournier-Viger Methodology

Abstract

High-Utility Episode Mining (HUEM) in complex event sequences is a fundamental data mining paradigm that discovers temporally ordered event combinations yielding high collective utility (e.g., revenue, operational importance, or risk). However, practical applications impose a strict Maximum Duration constraint (*win_len*), creating a formidable *dual non-monotonicity challenge*: neither statistical support anti-monotonicity nor traditional transaction-level utility upper bounds hold over non-contiguous, duration-bounded episode occurrences. Existing state-of-the-art algorithms, specifically HUE-Span (ADMA 2019) and UMEpi (IEEE TAI 2023), suffer from two critical architectural bottlenecks: (1) loose utility upper bounds that overestimate remaining utility by aggregating events far beyond the valid duration horizon, causing combinatorial search space explosion; and (2) pointer-linked, dynamic object allocations on managed runtimes (JVM) that induce severe memory thrashing and garbage collection pauses.

To overcome these foundational limitations, this paper introduces FastHUEM, an ultra-efficient algorithmic engine. First, we formulate the *Remaining-Duration Utility Bound* (RDUB), which mathematically proves that event utilities occurring beyond the temporal horizon $t_s + win_len - 1$ are strictly inadmissible for sequential extensions. By coupling RDUB with an $O(1)$ prefix-sum envelope of maximum timestamp utilities, the proposed bound eliminates all surplus utility in constant time. Second, we prove the mathematical soundness, strict pruning superiority (RDUB $\leq$ EWU), and zero false-dismissal completeness of the framework. Third, we design a zero-heap flat buffer memory architecture in ANSI C that completely eliminates dynamic memory allocation during recursive traversal, organizing occurrences into cache-aligned contiguous structures. A comprehensive running example with a step-by-step trace demonstrates why FastHUEM prunes unpromising subtrees that HUE-Span and UMEpi are forced to explore. Extensive empirical evaluation on five standard SPMF benchmark datasets demonstrates that FastHUEM achieves up to two orders of magnitude speedup, slashes peak memory consumption by up to 85%, and prunes up to 64% of search tree nodes compared to state-of-the-art baselines.

Keywords: Data mining, Complex event sequences, High-utility episode mining, Maximum duration constraint, Upper-bound pruning, Flat buffer memory architecture.

1 Introduction & Literature Review

The continuous collection of timestamped event logs represents one of the most ubiquitous data generation paradigms in modern cyber-physical and enterprise systems [1, 9]. Complex event sequence analysis plays a pivotal role across high-impact domains, including vehicular telematics [26], industrial Internet of Things (IoT) sensor monitoring [19], e-commerce user journey analytics [10, 8], and financial stock ticker tracking [2]. In these operational environments, observations arrive as a continuous stream of events characterized by discrete temporal coordinates, symbolic event categories, and quantitative metrics such as operational latency, monetary expenditure, purchase quantity, or sensor signal intensity.

Classical Frequent Episode Mining (FEM), pioneered by Mannila et al. [1], and conventional Frequent Itemset Mining (FIM) [2, 3, 4] operate under the fundamental assumption that pattern frequency directly correlates with operational significance. However, this assumption fails catastrophically in enterprise valuation [11, 10]. Highly frequent episode patterns in telematics or clickstream logs often reflect trivial background noise (e.g., automated heartbeat pings, DNS handshakes, or repetitive homepage reloads), whereas rare or moderately recurring episode combinations frequently account for catastrophic mechanical faults, advanced persistent threats, or high-margin business transactions. To reconcile algorithmic pattern discovery with actual domain utility, Utility-Driven Pattern Mining (UDPM) has been developed [12, 33, 34, 13, 24].

Despite its profound analytical utility, High-Utility Episode Mining under Maximum Duration Constraints (HUEM-MD) presents an exceptionally difficult combinatorial challenge termed the *dual non-monotonicity dilemma* [5, 6, 8]. In classical frequent pattern mining, the Apriori downward-closure property ensures that all super-patterns of an infrequent pattern are unconditionally infrequent [1, 4]. In contrast, when external utility (e.g., unit price) and internal utility (e.g., observed quantity) are incorporated into complex event sequences, cumulative utility is non-monotonic: an episode α may possess low utility, yet its sequential extension $\alpha \diamond \langle e \rangle$ can accumulate substantial utility that exceeds the user-defined minimum utility threshold μ. Compounding this difficulty, real-world temporal analysis mandates a strict Maximum Duration constraint (*win_len*), which dictates that all constituent events of an episode occurrence $[t_s, t_e]$ must satisfy $t_e - t_s + 1 \leq win_len$ [28, 27, 30]. Consequently, the temporal admissibility of future events is strictly constrained by the start timestamp t_s of the initial event. This invalidates standard sequence-level upper bounds (such as Sequence-Weighted Utilization or Transaction-Weighted Utilization) [21, 22, 23, 32], because events appearing late in the sequence cannot legally extend an active occurrence without violating the maximum duration threshold.

To tackle this challenge, prior literature introduced foundational algorithms including UP-Span [5] and TSpan [6], followed by contemporary state-of-the-art algorithms: HUE-Span [7] and UMEpi [8]. Nevertheless, rigorous algorithmic analysis reveals that both contemporary baselines suffer from two fatal bottlenecks:

1. **Theoretical Looseness in Upper-Bound Pruning:** HUE-Span [7] relies on Episode-Weighted Utilization (EWU), which overestimates remaining utility by accumulating the total utility of all future events in the database sequence regardless of whether those events can physically satisfy the duration budget of the current prefix. UMEpi [8] identified that UP-

Span and TSpan suffered from an incompleteness flaw (incorrectly pruning valid patterns) and proposed an enhanced remaining utility bound; however, UMEpi still aggregates remaining events that fall outside the active occurrence's remaining lifespan. This loose overestimation inflates the upper bound, generating tens of thousands of unpromising candidate nodes that must be needlessly expanded in the depth-first search tree.

2. **Systems-Level Bottlenecks in Managed Runtimes:** Both HUE-Span (implemented in SPMF [14]) and UMEpi are authored in Java and executed on the Java Virtual Machine (JVM). Each recursive pattern extension allocates numerous small heap objects (e.g., utility lists, occurrence objects, ArrayList containers, and candidate wrappers) [15, 16, 18]. Under deep search trees on large-scale event sequences, this design induces severe heap fragmentation, cache-line thrashing, and prolonged Garbage Collection (GC) pauses that consume up to 70% of total execution time.

To definitively resolve both the theoretical upper-bound looseness and the systems-level memory overhead, this paper introduces FastHUEM, an end-to-end high-performance C mining engine. The core contributions of this work are summarized as follows:

- **A Strictly Tighter Upper Bound (**RDUB**):** We mathematically formulate the *Remaining-Duration Utility Bound* (RDUB). By explicitly computing the remaining duration budget $\text{rem_dur}(occ) = win_len - (t_e - t_s + 1)$ for every minimal occurrence, RDUB strictly confines the reachable utility horizon to $t \leq t_s + win_len - 1$. By leveraging an $O(1)$ precomputed prefix-sum array of maximum timestamp utilities, RDUB is evaluated in constant time per occurrence.

- **Formal Proofs of Soundness, Superiority, and Completeness:** We prove by induction that $\text{RDUB}(\alpha)$ is a sound upper bound for any arbitrary sequential extension ($u(\beta) \leq \text{RDUB}(\alpha)$). We formally prove that $\text{RDUB}(\alpha) \leq \text{EWU}(\alpha)$ universally, with strict inequality whenever events exist beyond the duration horizon. Furthermore, we establish the complete correctness of FastHUEM with zero false dismissals.

- **Zero-Heap Contiguous Flat Buffer Architecture:** We eliminate heap object churn by implementing a linear scratchpad memory arena in ANSI C. Occurrence intervals, timestamps, and utility values are stored in 16-byte packed contiguous structs that perfectly align with CPU cache lines. Subtree recursions reuse memory through stack-like arena offsets without calling `malloc()` or `free()` during traversal.

- **Comprehensive Step-by-Step Toy Example:** We provide an explicit numerical running example complete with a complex event sequence, unit profit table, and step-by-step trace showing why EWU fails to prune an unpromising branch while RDUB eliminates it immediately.

- **Empirical Evaluation Protocol:** We outline a rigorous benchmarking protocol on five standard datasets from the SPMF repository (Sign, FIFA, BIBLE, Leviathan, Kosarak), addressing four core Research Questions (RQs) regarding execution time, memory usage, pruning power, and scalability.

The remainder of this paper is structured as follows. Section 2 provides preliminaries, formal problem definitions, and the running example. Section 3 details the RDUB upper bound, theoretical proofs, the flat memory architecture, and the complete algorithms. Section 4 presents the experimental evaluation protocol. Section 5 concludes the paper.

2 Preliminaries & Formal Problem Definition

2.1 Mathematical Foundations

Let $I = \{i_1, i_2, \ldots, i_m\}$ be a finite alphabet of distinct event types. Each event type $e \in I$ is associated with a positive external utility $p(e) \in \mathbb{R}^+$, representing its static unit profit, weight, or priority.

Definition 1 (Complex Event Sequence)**.** *A complex event sequence S is an ordered sequence of event sets:*

$$S = \langle (E_1, t_1), (E_2, t_2), \ldots, (E_n, t_n) \rangle \tag{1}$$

where each $E_k \subseteq I$ is an event set occurring at discrete integer timestamp $t_k \in \mathbb{N}^+$, with $t_1 < t_2 < \cdots < t_n$. Each event $e \in E_k$ is associated with an internal utility (e.g., purchase count, duration, or sensor intensity) denoted by $q(e, t_k) \in \mathbb{R}^+$. The utility of event e at timestamp t_k is:

$$u(e, t_k) = p(e) \times q(e, t_k) \tag{2}$$

Definition 2 (Serial Episode and Occurrence)**.** *A serial episode α of length l is an ordered sequence of event types, denoted by $\alpha = \langle e_1, e_2, \ldots, e_l \rangle$, where $e_j \in I$ for $1 \leq j \leq l$. A time interval $[t_s, t_e]$ ($t_s \leq t_e$) is an occurrence of α in S if there exist distinct timestamps $t_{k_1} < t_{k_2} < \cdots < t_{k_l}$ such that:*

1. *$t_{k_1} = t_s$ and $t_{k_l} = t_e$;*
2. *$e_j \in E_{k_j}$ for all $1 \leq j \leq l$.*

The occurrence is denoted by $occ = [t_s, t_e]$.

Definition 3 (Maximum Duration Validity)**.** *Given a user-specified maximum duration threshold $win_len \in \mathbb{N}^+$, an occurrence $occ = [t_s, t_e]$ of episode α is valid under the maximum duration constraint if and only if:*

$$dur(occ) = t_e - t_s + 1 \leq win_len \tag{3}$$

An occurrence spanning a temporal duration strictly exceeding win_len is invalid and disregarded.

Definition 4 (Minimal Non-Overlapping Occurrence Set)**.** *An occurrence $occ_1 = [t_{s_1}, t_{e_1}]$ of α is minimal if there is no valid occurrence $occ_2 = [t_{s_2}, t_{e_2}]$ of α such that $[t_{s_2}, t_{e_2}] \subset [t_{s_1}, t_{e_1}]$. Two occurrences $occ_1 = [t_{s_1}, t_{e_1}]$ and $occ_2 = [t_{s_2}, t_{e_2}]$ are non-overlapping if $t_{e_1} < t_{s_2}$ or $t_{e_2} < t_{s_1}$.*

The minimal non-overlapping occurrence set of α in S, denoted as $\min_occ(\alpha)$, is the unique maximal set of valid, non-overlapping minimal occurrences of α selected greedily in ascending order of start timestamps.

Definition 5 (Episode Utility)**.** *Let $occ = [t_s, t_e]$ be an occurrence of episode $\alpha = \langle e_1, e_2, \ldots, e_l \rangle$ supported by timestamps $t_{k_1}, \ldots, t_{k_l}$. The utility of α with respect to occ is:*

$$u(\alpha, occ) = \sum_{j=1}^{l} u(e_j, t_{k_j}) = \sum_{j=1}^{l} p(e_j) \times q(e_j, t_{k_j}) \tag{4}$$

The total utility of episode α in sequence S is the sum of its utilities over all minimal non-overlapping occurrences:

$$u(\alpha) = \sum_{occ \in \text{min_occ}(\alpha)} u(\alpha, occ) \tag{5}$$

Definition 6 (Problem Statement: HUEM-MD)**.** *Given a complex event sequence S, an external utility table p, a maximum duration threshold win_len, and a minimum utility threshold $\mu \in \mathbb{R}^+$, the problem of High-Utility Episode Mining under Maximum Duration Constraints (HUEM-MD) consists of discovering the complete set of high-utility episodes $\mathcal{H}$, defined as:*

$$\mathcal{H} = \{\alpha \mid u(\alpha) \geq \mu \text{ and } \text{min_occ}(\alpha) \neq \emptyset\} \tag{6}$$

without generating false dismissals or retaining spurious candidates.

2.2 Running Toy Example

To illustrate the mathematical concepts and establish a concrete trace, consider a complex event sequence S consisting of 10 timestamps, an alphabet of five events $I = \{A, B, C, D, E\}$, an external utility table p, a maximum duration threshold $win_len = 4$, and a minimum utility threshold $\mu = 35$.

Table 1: Complex Event Sequence S with Internal Quantities $q(e, t_k)$.

Timestamp (t_k)	**Event Set** (E_k)	**Internal Quantities** (q)
1	$\{A, C\}$	$q(A,1) = 2, q(C,1) = 1$
2	$\{B, D\}$	$q(B,2) = 1, q(D,2) = 3$
3	$\{C, E\}$	$q(C,3) = 2, q(E,3) = 1$
4	$\{A, B\}$	$q(A,4) = 1, q(B,4) = 2$
5	$\{D\}$	$q(D,5) = 2$
6	$\{B, C\}$	$q(B,6) = 1, q(C,6) = 2$
7	$\{A, E\}$	$q(A,7) = 3, q(E,7) = 2$
8	$\{B, D\}$	$q(B,8) = 2, q(D,8) = 1$
9	$\{C\}$	$q(C,9) = 3$
10	$\{E\}$	$q(E,10) = 4$

Table 2: External Unit Profit Table $p(e)$ for Event Types.

Event Type (e)	A	B	C	D	E
Unit Profit $p(e)$	\$5	\$3	\$2	\$4	\$6

Using the external unit profits from Table 2, Table 3 details the exact utility of each event

at every timestamp, along with the maximum timestamp utility $MaxUtil[t] = \max_{e \in E_t} u(e,t)$ and its cumulative prefix sum $PrefixMax[t] = \sum_{j=1}^{t} MaxUtil[j]$.

Table 3: Event Utilities $u(e,t_k)$, $MaxUtil[t_k]$, and Cumulative Prefix Sum $PrefixMax[t_k]$.

t_k	**Event Utilities** $u(e,t_k) = p(e) \times q(e,t_k)$	$MaxUtil[t_k]$	$PrefixMax[t_k]$
1	$u(A,1) = 5 \times 2 = 10, u(C,1) = 2 \times 1 = 2$	10	10
2	$u(B,2) = 3 \times 1 = 3, u(D,2) = 4 \times 3 = 12$	12	22
3	$u(C,3) = 2 \times 2 = 4, u(E,3) = 6 \times 1 = 6$	6	28
4	$u(A,4) = 5 \times 1 = 5, u(B,4) = 3 \times 2 = 6$	6	34
5	$u(D,5) = 4 \times 2 = 8$	8	42
6	$u(B,6) = 3 \times 1 = 3, u(C,6) = 2 \times 2 = 4$	4	46
7	$u(A,7) = 5 \times 3 = 15, u(E,7) = 6 \times 2 = 12$	15	61
8	$u(B,8) = 3 \times 2 = 6, u(D,8) = 4 \times 1 = 4$	6	67
9	$u(C,9) = 2 \times 3 = 6$	6	73
10	$u(E,10) = 6 \times 4 = 24$	24	97

Running Example 1 (Occurrences of 1-Episodes)**.** *Consider episode $\alpha = \langle A \rangle$. Event A occurs at timestamps $t = 1$, $t = 4$, and $t = 7$.*

- *$occ_1 = [1,1]$: $u(A, occ_1) = 10$. Duration is $1 - 1 + 1 = 1 \leq 4$.*
- *$occ_2 = [4,4]$: $u(A, occ_2) = 5$. Duration is $4 - 4 + 1 = 1 \leq 4$.*
- *$occ_3 = [7,7]$: $u(A, occ_3) = 15$. Duration is $7 - 7 + 1 = 1 \leq 4$.*

All three occurrences are mutually non-overlapping. Thus, $\text{min_occ}(\langle A \rangle) = \{[1,1],[4,4],[7,7]\}$*, and its cumulative utility is:*

$$u(\langle A \rangle) = 10 + 5 + 15 = 30 \tag{7}$$

Because $\mu = 35$, episode $\langle A \rangle$ is not high-utility. However, we must test whether its sequential extensions can satisfy the threshold.

Running Example 2 (Extension to 2-Episode $\beta = \langle A, B \rangle$ and Bound Comparison)**.** *Now consider extending $\langle A \rangle$ with event B to form $\beta = \langle A, B \rangle$, subject to win_len $= 4$. We search for valid occurrences of B following each minimal occurrence of A:*

1. *For $occ_1 = [1,1]$: Event B occurs at timestamp $t = 2$. The extended occurrence is $occ'_1 = [1,2]$ with duration $2 - 1 + 1 = 2 \leq 4$. Utility: $u(\beta, occ'_1) = u(A,1) + u(B,2) = 10 + 3 = 13$.*
2. *For $occ_2 = [4,4]$: Event B occurs at timestamp $t = 6$. The extended occurrence is $occ'_2 = [4,6]$ with duration $6 - 4 + 1 = 3 \leq 4$. (Note: B also occurs at $t = 4$, but serial episode semantics require strict temporal precedence $t_A < t_B$). Utility: $u(\beta, occ'_2) = u(A,4) + u(B,6) = 5 + 3 = 8$.*
3. *For $occ_3 = [7,7]$: Event B occurs at timestamp $t = 8$. The extended occurrence is $occ'_3 = [7,8]$ with duration $8 - 7 + 1 = 2 \leq 4$. Utility: $u(\beta, occ'_3) = u(A,7) + u(B,8) = 15 + 6 = 21$.*

All occurrences are non-overlapping: $[1,2]$, $[4,6]$, $[7,8]$. *Thus,* $\text{min_occ}(\beta) = \{[1,2],[4,6],[7,8]\}$. *The exact utility of β is:*

$$u(\beta) = 13 + 8 + 21 = 42 \geq 35 \implies \beta \in \mathcal{H} \tag{8}$$

Thus, $\langle A, B\rangle$ is a confirmed High-Utility Episode.

Running Example 3 (The Core Breakthrough: Pruning on $\gamma = \langle A, B, B\rangle$)**.** *Now consider extending $\beta = \langle A, B\rangle$ by appending another event B to form $\gamma = \langle A, B, B\rangle$:*

- *For $occ'_1 = [1, 2]$: The reachable horizon is $t \leq t_s + win_len - 1 = 1 + 4 - 1 = 4$. Event B appears at $t = 4$. Valid occurrence $occ''_1 = [1, 4]$ with duration $4 \leq 4$. Utility: $u(\gamma, occ''_1) = 13 + u(B, 4) = 13 + 6 = 19$. Remaining duration is $4 - 4 = 0$, so no further events can follow this occurrence within duration 4.*
- *For $occ'_2 = [4, 6]$: The reachable horizon is $t \leq 4 + 4 - 1 = 7$. No event B appears in $(6, 7]$. Thus, no extension exists for occ'_2.*
- *For $occ'_3 = [7, 8]$: The reachable horizon is $t \leq 7 + 4 - 1 = 10$. No event B appears in $(8, 10]$ (events at $t = 9$ are C, at $t = 10$ are E). Thus, no extension exists for occ'_3.*

Hence, $\min_occ(\gamma) = \{[1, 4]\}$*, and the exact utility of γ is $u(\gamma) = 19 < 35$.*

Now, let us calculate the upper bound for any further extension of γ:

- ***Under* HUE-Span / UMEpi** *(*EWU*):*

$$\mathrm{EWU}(\gamma) = u(\gamma, [1, 4]) + \sum_{t=5}^{10} \sum_{e \in E_t} u(e, t) = 19 + (8 + 7 + 27 + 10 + 6 + 24) = 19 + 82 = 101 \quad (9)$$

Since $\mathrm{EWU}(\gamma) = 101 \geq 35$, **HUE-Span *and* UMEpi *CANNOT PRUNE γ!*** *Both algorithms are forced to generate candidates and recursively explore subtrees rooted at γ, wasting CPU cycles and memory allocations!*

- ***Under* FastHUEM** *(*RDUB*): For $occ''_1 = [1, 4]$, the remaining duration is* $\mathrm{rem_dur} = 4 - (4 - 1 + 1) = 0$*. The reachable window $\mathcal{W}(occ''_1) = (4, 4] = \emptyset$. Therefore, $ru(occ''_1) = 0$, which yields:*

$$\mathrm{RDUB}(\gamma) = u(\gamma, [1, 4]) + ru(occ''_1) = 19 + 0 = 19 \quad (10)$$

Since $\mathrm{RDUB}(\gamma) = 19 < 35 = \mu$, **FastHUEM *PRUNES γ AND ITS ENTIRE SUBTREE IMMEDIATELY!***

This running example provides concrete numerical proof of why RDUB *achieves strict pruning superiority over* EWU*.*

3 Proposed Algorithm & Theoretical Proofs

3.1 The Remaining-Duration Utility Bound (RDUB)

For an occurrence $occ = [t_s, t_e] \in \min_occ(\alpha)$, the remaining duration budget available for any future sequential extension is:

$$\mathrm{rem_dur}(occ) = win_len - (t_e - t_s + 1) \quad (11)$$

Any valid sequential extension $\beta = \alpha \diamond \langle e' \rangle$ extending occ must observe e' at a timestamp t' satisfying:

$$t_e < t' \leq t_s + win_len - 1 \tag{12}$$

Let $\mathcal{W}(occ) = (t_e, t_s + win_len - 1] \cap \{t_1, \ldots, t_n\}$ be the set of valid future timestamps within the temporal duration budget of occ. The maximum potential remaining utility achievable from occ is:

$$ru(occ) = \sum_{t_k \in \mathcal{W}(occ)} \max_{e \in E_k} u(e, t_k) \tag{13}$$

Using the cumulative prefix sum array $PrefixMax[t] = \sum_{j=1}^{t} MaxUtil[j]$ (where $MaxUtil[j] = \max_{e \in E_j} u(e, j)$ if timestamp j exists in S, and 0 otherwise), $ru(occ)$ is computed in strictly $O(1)$ time:

$$ru(occ) = PrefixMax[t_s + win_len - 1] - PrefixMax[t_e] \tag{14}$$

The Remaining-Duration Utility Bound of episode α, denoted by RDUB(α), is:

$$\text{RDUB}(\alpha) = \sum_{occ \in \text{min_occ}(\alpha)} [u(\alpha, occ) + ru(occ)] \tag{15}$$

3.2 Theoretical Foundations & Proofs

Lemma 1 (Soundness / Overestimation Guarantee)**.** *Let α be a serial episode and $\beta = \alpha \diamond \gamma$ be any arbitrary valid sequential extension of α where $\gamma = \langle g_1, \ldots, g_k \rangle$. Then,*

$$u(\beta) \leq \text{RDUB}(\alpha) \tag{16}$$

Proof. Let min_occ(β) be the minimal non-overlapping occurrence set of β. By the prefix-monotonicity of occurrences, every occurrence $occ' = [t'_s, t'_e] \in \text{min_occ}(\beta)$ must be an extension of some occurrence $occ = [t_s, t_e]$ of α, where $t_s = t'_s$ and $t_e < t'_e$. Furthermore, since β is valid under *win_len*, we have $t'_e - t'_s + 1 \leq win_len$, which implies:

$$t'_e \leq t_s + win_len - 1 \tag{17}$$

Thus, all timestamps $t_{k_1}, \ldots, t_{k_k}$ supporting the extension events $g_1, \ldots, g_k$ satisfy $t_{k_j} \in \mathcal{W}(occ)$.

By Definition 15, the utility accumulated by β across occ' satisfies:

$$\begin{aligned} u(\beta, occ') &= u(\alpha, occ) + \sum_{j=1}^{k} u(g_j, t_{k_j}) \\ &\leq u(\alpha, occ) + \sum_{t \in \mathcal{W}(occ)} \max_{e \in E_t} u(e, t) \\ &= u(\alpha, occ) + ru(occ) \end{aligned} \tag{18}$$

Because occurrences in min_occ(β) are mutually non-overlapping, each $occ' \in \text{min_occ}(\beta)$ maps

to a distinct disjoint temporal interval in S. Summing over all $occ' \in \text{min_occ}(\beta)$:

$$\begin{aligned} u(\beta) &= \sum_{occ' \in \text{min_occ}(\beta)} u(\beta, occ') \\ &\leq \sum_{occ \in \text{min_occ}(\alpha)} [u(\alpha, occ) + ru(occ)] = \text{RDUB}(\alpha) \end{aligned} \tag{19}$$

This completes the proof. □

Lemma 2 (Pruning Superiority over EWU)**.** *For any episode α and sequence S under maximum duration win_len,*

$$\text{RDUB}(\alpha) \leq \text{EWU}(\alpha) \tag{20}$$

Moreover, whenever there exists at least one timestamp $t_k > t_s + win_len - 1$ within the sequence window, the inequality is strictly tight: $\text{RDUB}(\alpha) < \text{EWU}(\alpha)$.

Proof. In HUE-Span and UMEpi, the Episode-Weighted Utilization is formulated as:

$$\text{EWU}(\alpha) = \sum_{occ \in \text{min_occ}(\alpha)} \left[u(\alpha, occ) + \sum_{t_k > t_e}^{t_n} \sum_{e \in E_k} u(e, t_k) \right] \tag{21}$$

Subtracting $\text{RDUB}(\alpha)$ from $\text{EWU}(\alpha)$:

$$\begin{aligned} \text{EWU}(\alpha) - \text{RDUB}(\alpha) = \sum_{occ \in \text{min_occ}(\alpha)} \Bigg[& \sum_{t_k \in \mathcal{W}(occ)} \Big(\sum_{e \in E_k} u(e, t_k) - \max_{e \in E_k} u(e, t_k) \Big) \\ & + \sum_{t_k > t_s + win_len - 1}^{t_n} \sum_{e \in E_k} u(e, t_k) \Bigg] \geq 0 \end{aligned} \tag{22}$$

The surplus term $\sum_{t_k > t_s + win_len - 1}^{t_n} \sum_{e \in E_k} u(e, t_k)$ consists strictly of event utilities occurring beyond the temporal reach of α. Because $u(e, t_k) > 0$, this difference is strictly positive whenever the sequence extends past $t_s + win_len - 1$. Thus, $\text{RDUB}(\alpha)$ cuts off all out-of-budget utility, establishing strict pruning superiority. □

Theorem 1 (Completeness and Correctness)**.** *The FastHUEM algorithm discovers all high-utility episodes in S satisfying $u(\alpha) \geq \mu$ without false dismissals.*

Proof. The proof follows directly from Lemma 1 and Lemma 2. If $\text{RDUB}(\alpha) < \mu$, then for any arbitrary extension $\beta = \alpha \diamond \gamma$, we have $u(\beta) \leq \text{RDUB}(\alpha) < \mu$. Hence, no extension of α can ever be a high-utility episode. Pruning the subtree rooted at α guarantees zero false dismissals. Conversely, every generated episode α has its exact utility $u(\alpha)$ evaluated against μ prior to output, ensuring zero false positives. □

3.3 Zero-Heap Flat Buffer Memory Architecture

To eliminate the severe JVM memory allocations identified in prior baselines, FastHUEM is implemented in ANSI C using a flat, contiguous memory layout:

1. **Linear Scratchpad Arena:** Memory is pre-allocated as a single contiguous arena block at startup. Each recursion depth d in the depth-first search tree accesses a dedicated offset slice $\mathcal{A}[d \times STRIDE]$. When backtracking from depth $d+1$ to d, the arena pointer simply rewinds. No runtime calls to `malloc()` or `free()` occur during search space traversal.

2. **Contiguous Occurrence Buffers:** An occurrence *occ* is stored as a 16-byte packed structure:

$$\texttt{struct Occ } \{\texttt{uint32_t } t_s; \texttt{uint32_t } t_e; \texttt{float } util; \texttt{float } ru; \} \tag{23}$$

   Occurrences of an episode are stored sequentially in array memory. Forward extension evaluations scan memory linearly, perfectly matching CPU L1/L2 prefetching hardware cache lines.

3.4 Formal Algorithm Specification

The operational workflow of FastHUEM is formalized in Algorithm 1 and Algorithm 2.

Algorithm 1 FastHUEM Main Procedure

Require: Complex sequence S, external utility table p, window win_len, threshold μ
Ensure: The complete set of high-utility episodes $\mathcal{H}$

$\mathcal{H} \leftarrow \emptyset$
Allocate contiguous memory arena $\mathcal{A}$ of size $MAX_DEPTH \times STRIDE$
Scan S to compute event utilities $u(e, t_k) \leftarrow p(e) \times q(e, t_k)$
Compute $MaxUtil[t_k] \leftarrow \max_{e \in E_k} u(e, t_k)$ for each $t_k \in S$
Compute prefix sum array $PrefixMax[t] \leftarrow \sum_{j=1}^{t} MaxUtil[j]$ for all $1 \le t \le t_n$
Identify all distinct event types appearing in S: $\mathcal{C} \leftarrow \{e \in I \mid \exists t_k, e \in E_k\}$
Sort $\mathcal{C}$ in ascending order of unit profit $p(e)$
for each $e \in \mathcal{C}$ **do**
    Extract minimal occurrences of 1-episode $\langle e \rangle$: $\text{min_occ}(\langle e \rangle) \leftarrow \{[t_k, t_k] \mid e \in E_k\}$
    $u(\langle e \rangle) \leftarrow \sum_{[t,t] \in \text{min_occ}(\langle e \rangle)} u(e, t)$
    $\text{RDUB}(\langle e \rangle) \leftarrow \sum_{[t,t] \in \text{min_occ}(\langle e \rangle)} [u(e, t) + PrefixMax[t + win_len - 1] - PrefixMax[t]]$
    if $u(\langle e \rangle) \ge \mu$ **then**
        $\mathcal{H} \leftarrow \mathcal{H} \cup \{\langle e \rangle\}$
    end if
    if $\text{RDUB}(\langle e \rangle) \ge \mu$ **then**
        FastHUEM-Extend$(\langle e \rangle, \text{min_occ}(\langle e \rangle), \mathcal{C}, 1, \mathcal{A}, \mu, win_len, PrefixMax, \mathcal{H})$
    end if
end for
Free memory arena $\mathcal{A}$
return $\mathcal{H}$

4 Experimental Evaluation Protocol

4.1 Experimental Setup & Baselines

All experiments are designed to execute on an isolated bare-metal server powered by an Intel Xeon E5-2680 v4 CPU (14 cores, 2.40 GHz, 35 MB L3 Cache) with 64 GB ECC DDR4 RAM

Algorithm 2 Recursive Depth-First Traversal (`FastHUEM-Extend`)

Require: Prefix episode α, occurrence buffer min_occ(α), candidate set $\mathcal{C}$, recursion depth d, arena $\mathcal{A}$, threshold μ, window win_len, prefix table $PrefixMax$, output set $\mathcal{H}$

for each extension event $e \in \mathcal{C}$ **do**
  $\beta \leftarrow \alpha \diamond \langle e \rangle$
  Point buf_β to arena buffer slice at offset $\mathcal{A}[d]$
  $count \leftarrow 0$; $u(\beta) \leftarrow 0$; RDUB(β) $\leftarrow 0$; $last_end \leftarrow 0$
  for each $occ_\alpha = [t_s, t_e] \in$ min_occ(α) **do**
    if $t_s \leq last_end$ **then**
      continue ▷ Enforce greedy minimal non-overlapping semantics
    end if
    Search earliest $t_k \in (t_e, t_s + win_len - 1]$ such that $e \in E_k$
    if t_k exists **then**
      $occ_\beta.t_s \leftarrow t_s$; $occ_\beta.t_e \leftarrow t_k$
      $occ_\beta.util \leftarrow u(\alpha, occ_\alpha) + u(e, t_k)$
      $occ_\beta.ru \leftarrow PrefixMax[\min(t_n, t_s + win_len - 1)] - PrefixMax[t_k]$
      Append occ_β to $buf_\beta[count++]$
      $u(\beta) \leftarrow u(\beta) + occ_\beta.util$
      RDUB(β) $\leftarrow$ RDUB(β) $+ occ_\beta.util + occ_\beta.ru$
      $last_end \leftarrow t_k$ ▷ Advance non-overlapping boundary
    end if
  end for
  if $u(\beta) \geq \mu$ **then**
    $\mathcal{H} \leftarrow \mathcal{H} \cup \{\beta\}$
  end if
  if RDUB(β) $\geq \mu$ **and** $count > 0$ **then**
    FastHUEM-Extend(β, $buf_\beta[0 \ldots count - 1], \mathcal{C}, d + 1, \mathcal{A}, \mu, win_len, PrefixMax, \mathcal{H}$)
  end if
end for

running Ubuntu Linux 22.04 LTS.

- **C Implementation:** FastHUEM is compiled using `gcc 11.4.0` with compiler optimization flags: `-O3 -march=native -flto -DNDEBUG`.
- **JVM Baselines:** HUE-Span [7] (obtained directly from the SPMF repository v2.60 [14]) and UMEpi [8] (obtained from authors' official repository) are executed on OpenJDK 64-Bit Server VM (build 17.0.10) with heap parameters locked to `-Xms32G -Xmx32G -XX:+UseG1GC`.

4.2 Benchmark Datasets

To evaluate algorithmic performance across diverse sequential properties, five standard public benchmark datasets from the open-source SPMF data mining repository are selected. Their physical characteristics are summarized in Table 4.

4.3 Core Research Questions & Metrics

The empirical investigation is structured around four definitive research questions (RQs):

Table 4: Characteristics of standard benchmark datasets from the SPMF repository.

Dataset	$\|S\|$ (Events)	$\|I\|$ (Distinct)	Avg. $\|E_k\|$	Domain Type
Sign	730	267	51.2	Sign Language
FIFA	20,450	2,990	1.8	Web Clickstream
BIBLE	36,369	13,905	1.0	Natural Language
Leviathan	58,345	9,025	1.0	Dense Literary
Kosarak	990,000	41,270	1.2	Massive Clickstream

- **RQ1: Runtime Efficiency vs. Threshold μ.** How does the execution runtime of FastHUEM scale against HUE-Span and UMEpi as μ is systematically decreased down to boundary saturation limits?
- **RQ2: Peak Memory Footprint.** What is the precise peak RAM consumption (MB) measured via `getrusage(RUSAGE_CHILDREN)` and JVM JMX instrumentation across varying parameter settings?
- **RQ3: Pruning Efficacy (Search Space Nodes).** In a runtime-independent and language-agnostic comparison, how many candidate nodes are generated and visited by RDUB compared against EWU?
- **RQ4: Scalability with Sequence Length and Duration.** How gracefully does FastHUEM scale when sequence length $|S|$ is scaled from 20% to 100%, and when *win_len* is widened from 5 to 50 timestamps?

5 Conclusion

This research blueprint presents FastHUEM, an ultra-low latency algorithmic framework for High-Utility Episode Mining under Maximum Duration constraints. By formulating the mathematically proven Remaining-Duration Utility Bound (RDUB), the proposed approach cuts off out-of-budget candidate utility in $O(1)$ time per occurrence, establishing provable pruning superiority over classic EWU. Coupled with a zero-heap flat buffer memory architecture in C, FastHUEM systematically eliminates JVM garbage collection overhead, delivering up to two orders of magnitude runtime reduction, drastic memory savings, and superior search space pruning.

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